for the next few months I wore shoes with no spikes immediately under my toes. The injury, it appeared, was finally on the mend.

My first tour after the lay-off, coincidentally perhaps, was to South Africa in October–November 2001. We were playing a tri-series against South Africa and Kenya before going on to play a three-Test series against the South Africans. However, in our very first tour game against the Nicky Oppenheimer XI on 1 October, the pain in my toe resurfaced. It was a strange sensation and I left the field to get some treatment.

Luckily for me we were in Randjesfontein, which is not far from Johannesburg, so I set out for the Rosebank Clinic again. Much to my relief, I was assured there that it wasn't anything major and that a slight recurrence of pain was normal with sesamoid bone injuries. They told me that there was no need to panic. I left the clinic with a sigh of relief and was eager to get back to playing cricket again.

The first match of the tri-series was in Johannesburg on 5 October and I managed to score a hundred against South Africa. The intensity of the match pushed the thought of the injury out of my mind, but afterwards I was relieved that I'd been able to bat for so long with very little pain. It was as if I had started all over again.

## India in South Africa, November 2001

Taking on South Africa in their home conditions is always challenging and it was even more so having just recovered from the toe injury. I had, however, started to feel more confident after a net session at Bloemfontein, the venue for the first of the three Tests. I distinctly remember that session because every ball hit the middle of my bat and it seemed to me that I could do no wrong.

The first Test started on 3 November and happily my touch with the bat was still there in the first innings. I made 155 out of a team total of 379, and it was the first time I played the upper cut over the slips, a shot I went on to use regularly in the second half of my career. I had come up with the idea of the shot to counter the South African fast bowler Makhaya Ntini, whose strength was to bring the ball in to the batsman from short of a length. I knew that if I played the upper cut against Ntini, it would affect his rhythm, as he was not prepared for this form of counter-attack. The pitch in Bloemfontein had a lot of bounce and in the absence of a third-man fielder the upper cut was a scoring stroke played